



STUDENTS PARADE SUICIDE VICTIM KUMAR'S BODY DURING A PROTEST IN CHENNAI

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testers raised anti-government slogans and burnt effigies of DMK and Congress leaders while condemning India's support to Colombo. College students sat on the road for an hour with Kumar's body, protesting the indefinite closure of colleges by the state Government to control student activism. Taken aback by how the recent developments had isolated and handicapped him, Karunanidhi is trying hard to calm frayed tempers but without much success. "It is against our culture to politicise suicides for a 'cause'," said Karunanidhi.

The dead and the dying are not the only problems faced by Karunanidhi. Ailing in a city hospital, he is facing a multi-pronged attack with pro-LTTE outfits, united under the banner of the Sri Lankan Tamils Protection Movement, giving him unending nightmares. In the aftermath of Kumar's suicide, the Air Lanka office in Tiruchi and the Bank of Ceylon premises in Chennai were attacked. To stop escalation of violence, the DMK Government was hard-pressed to quell the bandh called by pro-LTTE forces on February 4, which also happens to be Sri Lanka's Independence Day. Despite heavy security, at many places buses were burnt and angry protesters

attacked the office of the Congress legislative member Gnanadesikan in Vellore. The leaders of the movement had got support from powerful sections of the society like the Lawyers' Association and Traders' Union. Swayed by the emotional outcry on this issue, lawyers were out on the streets in large numbers and shops were also shut to express solidarity for the plight of Tamils in Sri Lanka in the ongoing battle between the LTTE and Sri Lankan Army. But Karunanidhi can draw some comfort from the fact that the response for the bandh was rather lukewarm in most parts of the state.

An infuriated Congress, the DMK's lone ally, has asked the state Government to take stringent action against the perpetrators of the violence. Karunanidhi is willing to oblige, but in response would expect the Central Government to do more to help the cause of Tamils in Sri Lanka. To that extent External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee's visit to Sri Lanka, made under pressure from Tamil Nadu's political parties, provides him some cover. "Even Mukherjee was not happy with the outcome of the visit," says

Karunanidhi. Obviously, he cannot be seen endorsing the actions of the Centre completely, which would make him appear to have surrendered to the UPA leadership.

Observers feel the current sympathy for the Lankan Tamils won't reach the levels of the 1980s simply because of the presence of Tigers among the beleaguered Sri Lankan Tamil civilians. The LTTE lost much of its goodwill in the state after Rajiv Gandhi's assassination in May 1991. The Karunanidhi Government hopes to use this to pin down the pro-LTTE forces as 'merchants of violence'. The DMK has launched a parallel movement by the name of Sri Lankan Tamils Welfare and Rights Forum which last week vowed to conduct peaceful meetings throughout the state. The protests by Tamil United Liberation Front (TULF) under the leadership of V. Anandhasangaree in Sri Lanka to urge the Tigers to release Tamils from their captivity in the war zone is a sample of the plurality of Tamil voices in Sri Lanka, which pro-LTTE forces in Tamil Nadu have to take note of. Anandhasangaree has shot off a letter to Karunanidhi reiterating the same. Going by the strong anti-LTTE mood even among Tamilians in Sri Lanka, Karunanidhi seems to have made up his mind to harden his stand against the Tamil Tigers.

Karunanidhi's stance against the LTTE has created new political equations in the state. Caught between the hardline pro-LTTE and anti-LTTE forces, Karunanidhi has few options. On one side there is the AIADMK with its new allies, the Left parties, both against the Tamil Tigers, and on the other side there are the pro-LTTE forces—PMK, MDMK and VCK—under the Sri Lankan Tamils Protection Movement. And the DMK, which once commanded a rainbow alliance, is left with none but the Congress. To save the minority state Government, which survives on Congress support, incidentally the only ally left in the DMK-led Democratic Progressive Alliance of 2004, he is forced to act tough on pro-LTTE forces. Karunanidhi's battle against the Tamil Tigers may have just begun. ■